

travelling bag from His Excellency's brilliantly lighted saloon on the Southern Mahratta Railway, under the very noses of a strong body of police escorting the train."

The specialists

Railway robbers were broadly divided into three categories. The first was pickpockets or *uthaigiri* who strike fear in passengers even today. They usually worked alone and dressed well so as to not raise suspicions. Popular targets included ticket office windows and compartments.

The second category was made up of railway personnel who often took advantage of opportunities that presented themselves. For instance, in 1896–97, Bangalore saw the rise of the "Golden Gang", a group of guards who became experts at stealing silk and lace goods. Pilferage, whether by railway staff or experienced robbers, was quite common. Favourite items included cases of wine with reports of disappearing bottles becoming routine. The 1921 Simla Report of the Railway Police Committee noted that fruit thefts in the United Provinces (modern-day Uttar Pradesh) had also become 'notorious'. The Oudh and Rohilkhand Railway had to admit that not a single parcel of fresh fruits can reach its destination without suffering from the attacks of thieves", and the local government had to step in.

A third category was what the British classified as "criminal tribes" or professional groups of robbers belonging to a particular village or community. Highly decorated police officer Rai Bahadur M Pauparao Naidu in the fourth edition of his 1915 monograph *The History of Railway Thieves in India*, identified seven such classes with their own customs and modus operandi. These tribes were declassified after 1947.

The techniques

While pickpockets loitered near ticket booths to lift a wallet or bag, other thieves entered trains and waited for passengers to fall asleep or head to the dining car or refreshment room, leaving their belongings unattended. Robbers working in groups were known to rent a house near newly opened lines. They would split into teams and take turns going to the station to befriend pilgrims or passengers in trains only to rob them at night.